

Protect your next GitHub repository

Keep branch history safe while allowing normal commits and uploads.

1 Open the new repository's settings

Sign in as the owner. Open your repository on GitHub and click **Settings**. If it is empty, add a README or your first commit so a default branch exists.

2 Start a branch ruleset

In the settings sidebar, open **Rulesets** (under **Rules**, if shown). Choose **New ruleset**, then **New branch ruleset**.

3 Name it and turn it on

Use a name such as **Protect default branch**. Set enforcement to **Active** and leave the **Bypass list** empty.

4 Choose the branch to protect

Under **Target branches**, click **Add a target** and include the **default branch** (usually **main**). Leave exclusions empty.

5 Enable these two rules

For the same setup used on your public repositories:

- ☒ **Restrict deletions** - prevents deleting the protected branch.
- ☒ **Block force pushes** - prevents rewriting its existing history.

Leave other rules off for this simple setup.

6 Save and check

Click **Create**. Reopen the ruleset and confirm it is **Active**, targets the default branch, and has both rules enabled.

Repeat for each new repository.

Rules on an existing repository do not automatically protect future ones.

Private repo? GitHub Free supports this for public repositories. Private repositories in a personal account need GitHub Pro. An upgrade message means protection is not enabled. Your private imageboards repository has this limitation.